

Emotionally Safe Communication

Objective: Learn and practice ways to communicate in a safe, respectful, and supportive manner.

When emotions are strong, it's easy to say things that hurt or to shut down completely. Emotionally safe communication helps every family member feel **heard, respected, and understood**, even when there is disagreement.

1. Ground Rules for Safe Communication

- Speak one at a time (no interruptions).
- Use respectful language (no insults, yelling, or threats).
- Share from your own perspective (not assumptions about others).
- Allow "pause time" if emotions become overwhelming.
- End conversations respectfully, even if not fully resolved.

2. Structured Turn-Taking

- One person speaks at a time.
- The listener repeats back what they heard (not word-for-word, just the main point).
- The speaker confirms if they felt understood.
- Then the next person takes their turn.
- *use a timer with an agreed upon time frame for turn taking if appropriate

Example:

Speaker: "I felt hurt when you walked away during our talk."

Listener: "I hear that you felt hurt when I walked away."

Speaker: "Yes, that's right."

3. Using "I" Statements

"I" statements help share feelings without blaming or attacking.

Formula:

- I feel _____ (emotion)
- when _____ (behavior or situation)
- because _____ (impact on me)
- I need _____ (healthy request, not demand)

Example:

"You never listen to me!"

"I feel sad when I don't feel heard, because I want to feel close to you. I need us to set aside time to talk without distractions."

4. Setting Boundaries

Boundaries help create safety and respect in conversations.

It's okay to say:

- "I need a break. Let's talk in 20 minutes."
- "That topic feels too overwhelming right now. Can we revisit later?"
- "I can listen for 10 minutes, then I'll need to step away."

Healthy boundaries protect relationships, not hurt them. It is important to establish an agreed upon timeframe for when the conversation can safely resume.

5. Practice Activity for the Family

- Choose one family member to share a small concern (something low-stakes).
- Use structured turn-taking.
- Speaker uses an “I” statement.
- Listener reflects back what they heard.
- Family rotates so each person practices being Speaker and Listener.

6. Reflection Questions

- How did it feel to be listened to without interruption?
- What was hard about using “I” statements?
- How did boundaries help or make things easier?
- What do we want to practice more at home this week?

Remember: Safe communication is a skill. It takes practice, patience, and compassion. The goal is not perfection but building trust and respect in every conversation.